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Instructors' and learners' perspectives on using ChatGPT in English as a foreign language courses and its effect on academic integrity

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ABSTRACT

This mixed-methods study explored the perspectives of university instructors and learners of English as a foreign language (EFL) regarding ChatGPT's effectiveness for EFL learning and its implications for academic integrity. Twenty-four instructors and 135 learners engaged with ChatGPT for one trimester. After a training session, instructors incorporated ChatGPT into their teaching. At the trimester's end, questionnaires were distributed to gather participants' opinions on their experience with ChatGPT. Instructors also provided open-ended responses and participated in semistructured interviews. Instructors and learners both had positive attitudes about artificial intelligence (AI) use in EFL learning, especially for written work. Learners acknowledged, however, that they might conceal their ChatGPT use from instructors; many said they would have ChatGPT complete their homework, if possible. Customizing responses within a word limit and generating multiple answers to similar prompts were identified as ChatGPT capabilities that could lead to misuse. This study's practical implications, along with solutions for reducing the risk of AI-facilitated plagiarism, are discussed.

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AI language learning; ChatGPT and EFL; AI in education; academic integrity

Introduction

Today, artificial intelligence (AI) has a well-established presence in academic institutions (Gorichanaz, 2023). Progress in deep learning, AI, and natural language processing has resulted in sophisticated tools that educators and learners can use in educational processes. Among these innovations are AI chat tools powered by large language models (LLMs) that

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can produce responses to prompts that closely mimic human interaction. LLMs can create new information based on patterns and structures learned from training data and enable machines to recognize and generate human-like language (Zhao et al., 2023).

Chat Generative Pre-trained Transformer (ChatGPT) is one such AI technology, designed to simulate conversational exchanges based on user input. ChatGPT is built on the transformer architecture, a type of neural network introduced by Vaswani et al. (2017). Transformers use self-attention mechanisms to gauge the importance of different words in a sentence, thereby enhancing the understanding and generation of text (Vaswani et al., 2017). They are adept at handling follow-up questions, generating coherent content, paraphrasing, summarizing, and translating, as well as recognizing and correcting mistakes (Fergus et al., 2023). Additionally, ChatGPT's responses can be customized to meet users' needs in terms of response length and language level, among other aspects (for more information about ChatGPT's potential, see the ChatGPT release announcement; OpenAI, 2022).

Such tools have prompted concerns among educators about the future of education (Cotton et al., 2023; Farrokhniaa et al., 2023; Gao et al., 2024; Gorichanaz, 2023; Ibrahim et al., 2023; Jeon & Lee, 2023; Stokel-Walker, 2023; Tlili et al., 2023). Although ChatGPT and similar AI models can potentially enhance education, they also pose challenges, especially in terms of academic integrity (Farrokhniaa et al., 2023; Gao et al., 2024; Gorichanaz, 2023; Ibrahim et al., 2023; Jeon & Lee, 2023; Ventayen, 2023). Such systems can generate text that closely mimics human language, raising the possibility that learners could submit AI-generated material as their work. This could be a concern in English as a foreign language (EFL) instruction, as learners might be tempted to use ChatGPT to improve their grades or pass exams. It is important, then, to address this issue to maintain the integrity and value of assessments in higher education (Cotton et al., 2023; Gorichanaz, 2023; Ibrahim et al., 2023; Kohnke et al., 2023; Mijwil et al., 2023).

Problem statement

Shortly after ChatGPT's release in November 2022, there were numerous documented instances of learners using it for academic work (D'Agostino, 2023; Mitchell, 2022). Various institutions quickly took measures to curb the unethical use of ChatGPT, including banning ChatGPT on campuses (Cassidy, 2023; Johnson, 2023; Rosenblatt, 2023; Shen-Berro, 2023; Yang, 2023). Many noted, however, that it is impossible to ban (Kohnke et al., 2023). Despite such efforts, reports of

plagiarism involving ChatGPT continue to surface worldwide (Fallon, 2023; Mitchell, 2022).

Since banning is neither practical nor sustainable, other educational policies have favored a 'detection' approach. However, this leads to even more complex challenges. Although tools have been developed to detect ChatGPT-generated work, many have limited accuracy (Gorichanaz, 2023; Ibrahim et al., 2023; Mijwil et al., 2023), and students are sometimes wrongly accused of using ChatGPT (Gorichanaz, 2023; Klee, 2023). A detection tool's accuracy can change significantly with the addition of just one word (Ibrahim et al., 2023; Liang et al., 2023; Tlili et al., 2023). Such tools are especially unreliable for authors who are not native English speakers. Liang et al. (2023) reported that seven AI detectors incorrectly flagged 18 out of 91 TOEFL learner essays (19%) as AI generated; another surprisingly flagged 89 out of 91 essays (97%). This bias against EFL learners further complicates matters for both EFL instructors and learners.

Significance of this study

The increasing use of AI chatbots highlights the urgent need for research in AI-assisted language learning. While the term *AI language learning* is widely used (An et al., 2023), some studies have focused specifically on 'ChatGPT-assisted language learning' (Cai et al., 2023). Farrokhniaa et al. (2023) and Cotton et al. (2023) characterized ChatGPT as a 'double-edged sword' in education while Wu et al. (2023) advocated for more research on how to curb its misuse. Farrokhniaa et al. (2023) further emphasized that ChatGPT use in education is nascent, underscoring the need for more research in this area. Conducting research in different international contexts can help foster a holistic understanding of the effect of using ChatGPT and other LLMs in education (Gao et al., 2024).

Given their limited language proficiency, EFL learners may be strongly tempted to use ChatGPT to craft polished, error-free essays and present them as original work. AI-generated English compositions have received nearly perfect scores in different tests (Ibrahim et al., 2023). This study, therefore, explored EFL instructors' and learners' perspectives on the use and misuse of ChatGPT in EFL classrooms after using it regularly for one trimester.

Research objectives

This investigation aimed to answer the following question: What are the perspectives of EFL instructors and learners on using ChatGPT in EFL

learning and its potential effect on academic integrity? This study specifically focused on

- the appropriateness of using ChatGPT for different EFL skills and fields of study;
- ChatGPT features that lead to possible unethical use; and
- suggestions for reducing the risk of plagiarism when using ChatGPT in EFL learning.

Previous studies

ChatGPT in education

Early studies used content analysis and opinion-mining methods to study ChatGPT use in education (Gorichanaz, 2023; Jarrah et al., 2023; Sullivan et al., 2023; Taecharungroj, 2023; Tlili et al., 2023). A prominent theme in discussions on this topic pertains to AI use and academic integrity; other concerns relate to the risk of fostering laziness and possible detrimental effects on critical thinking. Many educators note that AI-generated content can present false or biased information; others note the need for updated definitions of cheating and a reconsideration of assessment methods. Nevertheless, many educators recommend adopting such technologies rather than prohibiting them, suggesting that ChatGPT can transform education by assisting teachers and learners. Others emphasize the need to resolve the tension between technological advancement and ethical considerations (Taecharungroj, 2023) while adopting a teaching philosophy that acknowledges AI's potential (Tlili et al., 2023). It is noteworthy, meanwhile, that learners' perspectives are underrepresented in this discussion (Sullivan et al., 2023).

ChatGPT and language instruction

Ji et al. (2022) found that AI could reduce language teachers' workload by serving as an evaluator, resource provider, needs analyst, and conversational partner in oral and written dialog. However, frequent misinterpretation, a tendency to overlook grammatical errors, and a lack of social engagement and emotional sensitivity caused some learners to lose interest in AI. More recently, Mohamed (2023) interviewed 10 EFL instructors and found mixed opinions regarding ChatGPT's efficacy. Some recognized its ability to provide quick, accurate answers to various questions while others raised concerns about its effects on learners' critical thinking and research skills. Jeon and Lee (2023), meanwhile, asked 11 language teachers to use ChatGPT in the classroom for two weeks and found generally positive attitudes. Four ChatGPT roles were identified (interlocutor, content provider, teaching assistant, evaluator), along with

three teacher roles (orchestrating resources, making students active investigators, raising AI-related ethical awareness).

Kohnke et al. (2023) found that while 12 college English instructors in Hong Kong had positive attitudes about using AI tools, they were uncertain about how to apply them and noted that AI should supplement rather than replace teaching. They felt that AI could help learners engage more with their work, receive instant feedback, and receive guidance on pronunciation, speaking, grammar, and critical thinking. However, they were also concerned about overreliance on ChatGPT and potential misuse. Gao et al. (2024) similarly found that EFL teachers believed LLMs could enhance students' academic achievement, language learning engagement, and understanding of complex ideas. They, too, were concerned about academic integrity, the neglect of traditional learning resources, changes in teachers' roles, and students' overreliance on LLMs. Moreover, teachers' previous experience with LLMs was found to shape their beliefs about using LLMs in language education.

Fewer studies, meanwhile, have considered learners' perspectives. Investigating language learners' perspectives on ChatGPT use, Cai et al. (2023) found that the factors affecting learners' performance expectancy included hedonic motivation for using ChatGPT and information system quality in terms of accuracy and efficiency. Further, learners' intention to use ChatGPT was positively associated with learning effectiveness. Liu and Ma (2023) explored ChatGPT's effectiveness in informal, non-classroom English learning, concluding that it is a promising tool for EFL learners. Yan (2023) investigated EFL learners' use of ChatGPT in a one-week writing practicum; the findings highlighted the affordance and potential applicability of ChatGPT while also raising concerns about academic integrity. Mahapatra (2024) found that feedback from ChatGPT positively affected students' academic writing ability, and students had positive perceptions of this effect. ChatGPT helped them generate ideas, work both independently and collaboratively, reduce brainstorming time, and complete tasks faster. It also helped the students organize essays, write better topic sentences, use broader vocabulary, and identify supporting details. Students regarded ChatGPT as reliable in terms of grammatical accuracy and explanations of language errors but also thought overreliance could negatively affect their motivation to think and hinder creativity.

Many previous studies used sentiment analysis approaches, were conducted within short timeframes, focused solely on either instructors' or learners' perspectives, or investigated ChatGPT use in writing courses only. This study aimed to fill these gaps by examining the perspectives of both instructors and learners following the practical and regular use

of ChatGPT during a full academic trimester in various types of EFL courses.

Method

Research design

Using a mixed-methods approach, this study collected both quantitative and qualitative data, which can provide greater richness in exploring the themes under investigation (Dörnyei, 2007). Quantitative data were obtained using questionnaires while qualitative data were collected through open-ended questions and a final semistructured interview.

Participants

Based on convenience sampling, the participants were 24 female university EFL instructors and 135 female students enrolled in an EFL program at a public Saudi university for women. Given the exploratory nature of the study, which does not claim to provide generalizable results, this sample size was deemed suitable. Most instructors had a PhD in EFL teaching ($n=21$) while three had a master's degree in the field. Their teaching experience ranged from five to 17 years ($M=13.7$, $SD = 1.01$). The EFL learners were adult native Arabic speakers at various undergraduate levels in the English program at the university (Table 1). The university review board approved the study and granted permission to collect data. Participating learners had been exposed to English in formal educational settings but had not spent significant time in English-speaking countries. Their ages ranged from 18 to 24 years ($M=21.3$, $SD = 1.03$). They were enrolled in a four-year bachelor's degree program in English language and literature, ranging from levels 3 to 10, which correspond to their first to fourth year of study. Their curriculum included English language courses (reading, writing, listening, grammar, and speaking), English literature courses (novels, drama, poetry), and Arabic–English translation and linguistics courses.

Table 1. Distribution of participants (learners) based on their academic level in completing a bachelor's degree in English.

Academic level	No.	%
Year 1 (levels 1, 2, 3)	36	26
Year 2 (levels 4, 5, 6)	39	28
Year 3 (levels 7, 8, 9)	33	24
Year 4 (levels 10, 11, 12)	27	20
Total	135	100

Instruments

Two electronic questionnaires were created. Instructors received one version (Supplementary Appendix 1) while learners received another (Supplementary Appendix 2). The instructors' questionnaire comprised four sections with 22 items total, each of which was rated using a five-point Likert scale ranging from 'strongly agree' to 'strongly disagree.' The final question was open-ended. The four sections covered

1. Courses and EFL skills ChatGPT is effective for
2. ChatGPT features that might allow plagiarism
3. Measures to restrict learners' negative exploitation of ChatGPT
4. Open-ended question: Please comment on your experience with using ChatGPT in your classes. Can you suggest other solutions to reduce the possible negative effects of ChatGPT on academic integrity?

The learners' questionnaire was prepared in Arabic to reduce any potential effect of second-language difficulty on the outcomes. The accuracy of the Arabic translation was verified by three specialists in Arabic-English translation. Back translation was used to ensure the accuracy of the translation. This questionnaire was divided into three sections, totaling 21 questions. Its sections included

1. Courses and EFL skills ChatGPT is effective for
2. ChatGPT features that might allow plagiarism
3. Learners' experience and perspectives regarding ChatGPT use in EFL classes

The questionnaires were developed following Cotton et al. (2023), Farrokhniaa et al. (2023), Jarrah et al. (2023), and Ibrahim et al. (2023). Furthermore, four EFL experts with experience using ChatGPT in teaching evaluated and validated both versions of the questionnaire. Their feedback led to multiple revisions. Additionally, three instructors and five learners responded to the questionnaires in a pilot study; their recommendations regarding clarity and wording were taken into consideration. The reliability of the instruments was assessed by calculating Cronbach's alpha, which yielded values of 0.820 and 0.891 for the instructors' and learners' questionnaires, respectively, indicating statistically acceptable reliability.

Semistructured interviews were conducted with the participant instructors at the end of the study to gather more qualitative data. Instructors were invited to share their experiences of using ChatGPT in their EFL classes.

Procedures

The study was conducted during the fall trimester of 2023, following the release of ChatGPT 3.5 in Saudi Arabia in August of that year. Before the start of the trimester, all participating instructors attended a virtual training session on ChatGPT. The session, led by the researcher, trained the instructors on using ChatGPT to ensure they would be comfortable using it in their teaching. The instructors were encouraged to explore the program’s potential and integrate it into their classes as needed. The training covered various topics, including but not limited to the following:

Writing prompts to generate responses, including using ChatGPT to

- brainstorm ideas
- offer feedback
- communicate
- translate into Arabic
- generate sample teaching essays
- provide synonyms

Instructors were not confined to using ChatGPT solely for these topics but were encouraged to creatively integrate it into their EFL teaching practices. They were instructed to train their learners on how to use ChatGPT during classes. These instructors taught a range of courses, including English language skills, English literature, linguistics, and translation (Table 2). They were also required to incorporate ChatGPT into in-class activities, homework, and assignments. However, its use in quizzes and tests was prohibited to comply with university regulations. Instructors were urged to report any issues to the researcher, such as learners who could not access the technology, any difficulties using ChatGPT, or learner overdependence on ChatGPT. Learners downloaded ChatGPT 3.5 onto their electronic devices (phones and tablets) and used the app as advised by their instructors. At the end of the trimester, opinions about using ChatGPT in EFL classes were gathered from both EFL learners and instructors. Participants received electronic questionnaire links *via* their university e-mail accounts; learner responses were voluntary and anonymous. Learners were encouraged to be candid, with assurances that their feedback would not affect their course grades. Nine

Table 2. EFL courses in which participant instructors used ChatGPT.

EFL courses	No.	%
English language skills	10	41.6
English literature	7	29
Linguistics	4	16.6
Translation	3	12.5
Total	24	100

instructors did not respond to the open-ended question in the questionnaire, with one noting that their previous responses addressed the topic. However, all instructors participated in the end-of-trimester semistructured interview. Consent was obtained to record and reproduce participants' comments as needed.

Data analysis

Quantitative analysis of the closed-ended questions included descriptive statistics (frequencies and percentages) summarizing participants' perceptions and concerns about using ChatGPT in EFL learning; SPSS was used for analysis. For the open-ended questions and the semistructured interviews with instructors, qualitative analysis was conducted using content analysis to identify the main themes. Participants' responses were transcribed and edited. Following Saldaña (2009), the data underwent manual coding through content analysis and thematic coding. Codes were generated, categorized into units, and further synthesized into six main themes by two coders, whose interindividual reliability was calculated using Cohen's Kappa. The Kappa value was 0.8, indicating a high level of agreement (McHugh, 2012). After manual coding, NVivo 11 was used to organize data and explore patterns and relationships.

Quantitative results

Supplementary Appendix 3 (Tables 3–8) presents the detailed descriptive statistical results, including frequencies, percentages, means, and standard deviations for all items in the instructors' and learners' questionnaires.

The first part of the questionnaires for learners and instructors examined their general views about ChatGPT use in EFL classes and the skills and courses it could be beneficial for.

Courses and fields of study ChatGPT can be effective for

Instructors' perspective

Overall, instructors had a positive view of ChatGPT's potential to assist EFL learners; 62.5% ($M=3.7$, $SD = 0.6$) agreed or strongly agreed that AI could be beneficial in all EFL courses. A significant 70.9% ($M=3.6$, $SD = 0.7$) of instructors agreed or strongly agreed that ChatGPT can improve learners' writing ability. Up to 90% ($M=4.2$, $SD = 0.9$) agreed or strongly agreed that ChatGPT is especially helpful for assisting learners with their assignments and essays. While 54.2% ($M=3.6$, $SD = 0.5$) agreed that ChatGPT can help develop communicative skills, others were neutral or disagreed. Most also recognized ChatGPT's usefulness in

content-based courses, such as literature and linguistics, as well as translation skill courses (Figure 1).

Learners' perspective

About 46% ($M=3.1$, $SD = 0.3$) of learners were likely to turn to ChatGPT for courses they disliked. Most, however, did not think it was wise to rely on ChatGPT for all of their courses simply to improve their GPA; 51.4% ($M=3.1$, $SD = 0.4$) agreed or strongly agreed that they would let ChatGPT complete their homework if given the chance. While a large percentage (54.2%) ($M=3.4$, $SD = 0.5$) believed ChatGPT aided their communication skills—a finding nearly identical to that from the instructors' survey—some were neutral (31.4%) or disagreed (14.3%). Indeed, most learners (80%) ($M=4$, $SD = 0.9$) agreed and strongly agreed that ChatGPT is extremely useful for writing essays, echoing the instructors' feedback. Similar to the instructors' opinions, ChatGPT was deemed valuable for content-heavy courses, such as literature and linguistics, but not for translation courses. Additionally, 54.3% ($M=3.5$, $SD = 0.5$) of learners planned to use ChatGPT in the future to draft job applications (Figure 2).

Features of ChatGPT that might allow plagiarism

The second section of the questionnaires focused on features of ChatGPT that could lead to its misuse by learners.

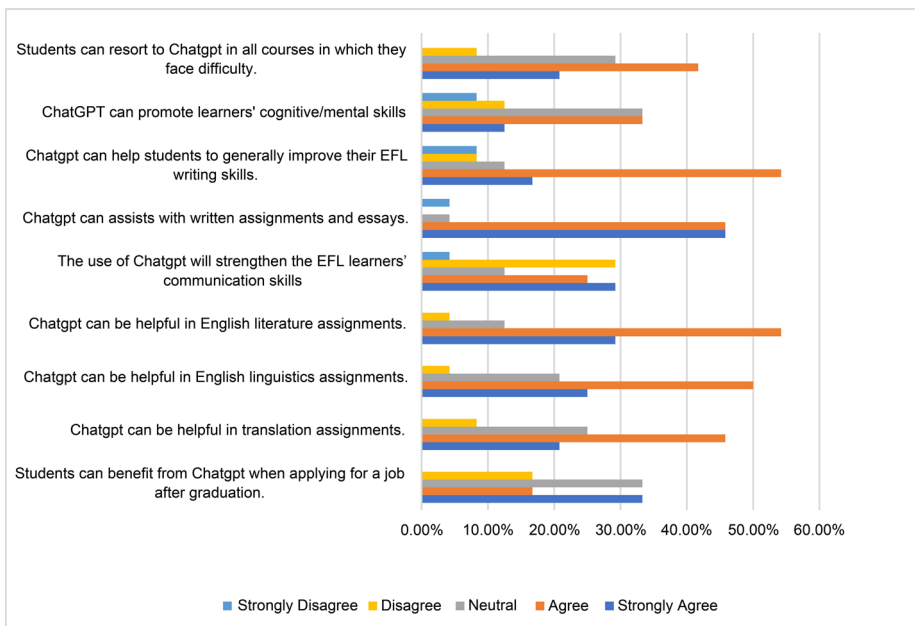


Figure 1. Instructors' perspectives on courses and areas in which ChatGPT can be effective.

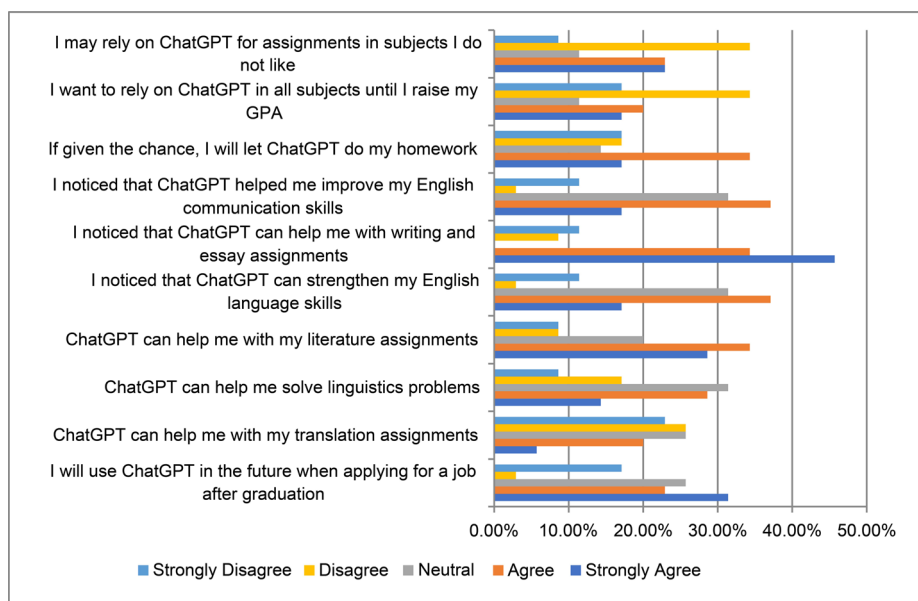


Figure 2. Learners' perspectives on courses and areas in which ChatGPT can be effective.

Instructors' perspective

Instructors believed that key features of ChatGPT could potentially enable learners to plagiarize. Among them, 37.5% strongly agreed and 50% agreed ($M=4.2$, $SD = 0.9$) that ChatGPT's ability to generate a specified word count is a concern. Additionally, 70.8% ($M=3.9$, $SD = 0.7$) agreed that ChatGPT's capacity to provide varied responses to the same prompt might be misused, because it allows each learner to generate a unique answer. While 54.3% ($M=3.6$, $SD = 0.6$) acknowledged that ChatGPT's generation of text not found on other websites could encourage plagiarism, there was skepticism regarding whether this would necessarily lead to plagiarism. Not all instructors were convinced that ChatGPT's ability to produce text at a learner's writing level is a direct path to plagiarism. Plagiarism software's inability to identify text copied from ChatGPT was not considered a significant factor in the potential unethical use of AI (Figure 3).

Learners' perspectives

Learners were largely unaware that most plagiarism detection tools are somewhat ineffective against AI-generated content. ChatGPT's ability to generate multiple answers to the same question was seen as a potential avenue for abuse, with 68.6% ($M=3.8$, $SD = 0.6$) of learners recognizing that it could lead to plagiarism, aligning with the instructors' opinions.

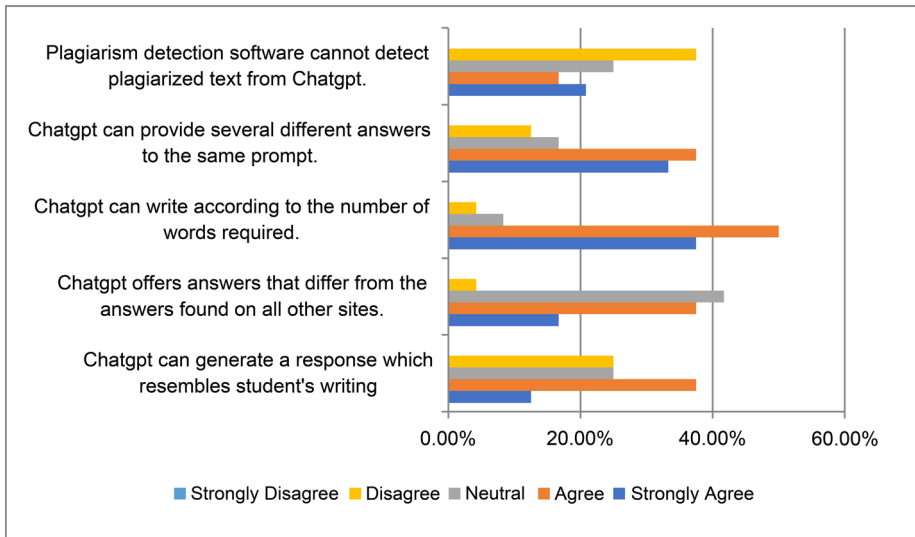


Figure 3. Instructors' perspectives on ChatGPT features that promote plagiarism.

Among learners, 60% ($M=3.4$, $SD = 0.6$) agreed that ChatGPT's unique responses, which differ from those commonly found online, pose a risk to academic integrity. Like instructors, learners did not believe that ChatGPT's ability to tailor responses to different English proficiency levels could facilitate misuse, possibly because of a lack of awareness about this feature (Figure 4).

Possible ways to minimize unethical ChatGPT use

The third section of the questionnaire evaluated possible solutions for minimizing plagiarism using ChatGPT from EFL instructors' perspectives (Figure 5).

Instructors believed the most effective way to mitigate ChatGPT misuse by learners is to allocate a significant portion of assessment to classwork (16.7% strongly agreeing and 62.5% agreeing ($M=3.9$, $SD = 0.9$)) and compare classwork with submitted assignments. Additionally, a highly favored approach was for instructors to review answers with learners individually, ensuring they crafted the responses themselves, with 33.3% strongly agreeing and 54.2% agreeing ($M=4.2$, $SD = 0.9$). Another strategy was to maintain direct communication with learners to understand their needs, with 37.5% strongly agreeing and 58.3% agreeing ($M=4.2$, $SD = 1.0$). However, instructors did not agree that restricting ChatGPT solely to classroom use is an effective way to control its use. Similarly, the idea of limiting evaluations only to classwork did not receive substantial support from most instructors.

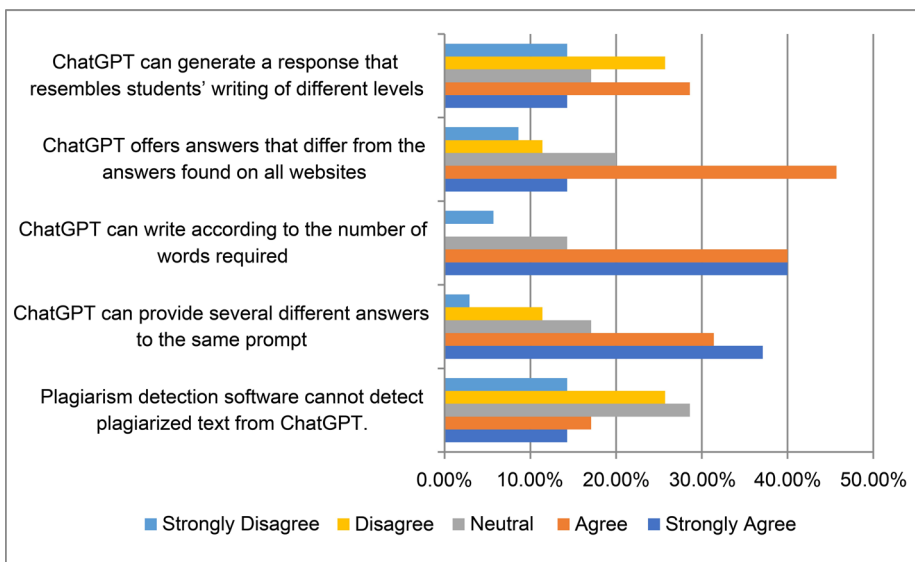


Figure 4. Learners' perspectives on ChatGPT features that promote plagiarism.

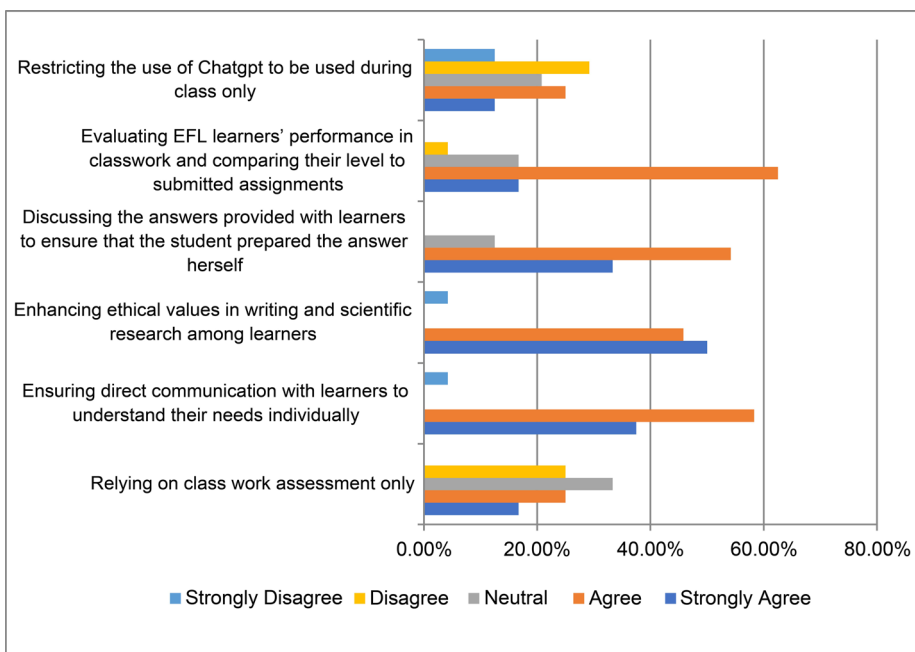


Figure 5. Instructors' perspectives on restricting learners' negative exploitation of ChatGPT.

Overall perspectives of learners on ChatGPT use in EFL classes

This section analyzes learners' honesty and the academic ethics they observed while using ChatGPT in EFL classes (Figure 6).

While 37.14% ($M=2.7$, $SD = 0.2$) of learners disagreed with the idea that submitting an AI-generated assignment is preferable to submitting

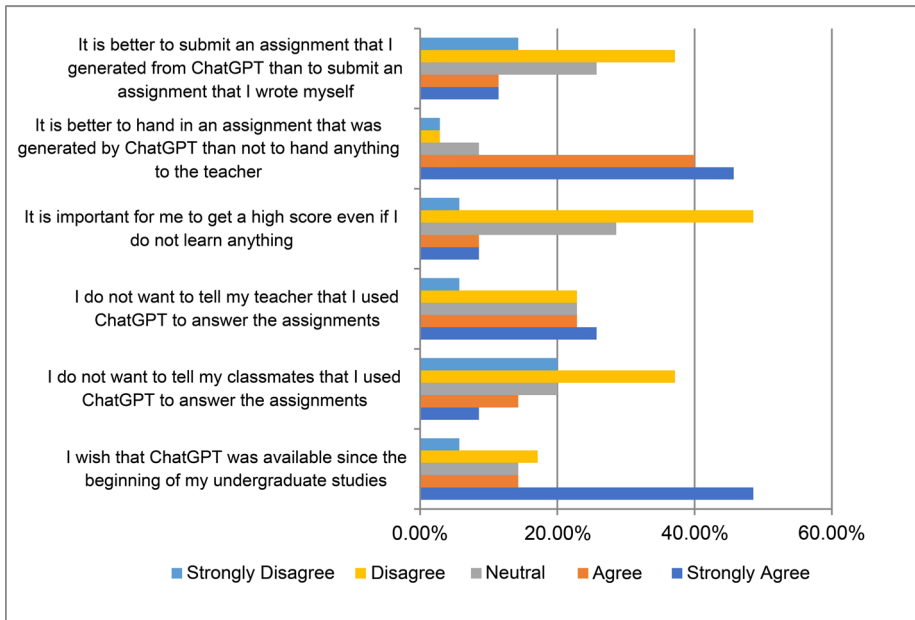


Figure 6. Learners' experiences and perspectives after using ChatGPT in EFL classes.

one they wrote themselves, a substantial 22.86% agreed with the statement. When unable to complete an assignment, most (85.17%, $M=4.2$, $SD = 0.9$) believed it would be better to submit something generated by ChatGPT than nothing at all. Over half (54.28%, $M=2.6$, $SD = 0.3$) recognized the importance of actual learning over their assignment scores while the rest were either neutral (28.57%) or prioritized scores over learning (17.14%). Some were willing to inform their teachers about using the AI tool for assistance, but about 48% ($M=3.4$, $SD = 0.4$) preferred to keep this information private. In general, learners were more open about their use of ChatGPT with peers than with teachers. Regarding its role in learning, most learners (62.86%, $M=3.8$, $SD = 0.8$) wished ChatGPT had been available during their earlier English learning stages.

Qualitative results

Analysis of qualitative data revealed the following main themes.

Embracing, rather than banning, the technology

Instructors broadly agreed on the need to embrace technology and maximize its educational benefits. They recognized the impracticality of barring learners from using technology. They praised ChatGPT as an outstanding teaching tool, especially beneficial for EFL learners who require extensive exposure to and interaction with the foreign language.

One instructor described ChatGPT as an ‘electronic individual tutor...for every student and available at all times.’ Instructors argued that ChatGPT’s educational potential should not be overshadowed by concerns about academic integrity. Some observed that new technologies often face skepticism and resistance from traditional educators, citing the initial reception of electronic dictionaries, word processor spellcheckers, and paraphrasing tools. One instructor commented, ‘I think there are always unjustified worries about new technologies and their misuse. There were before search engines, wikis, and electronic resources, and all of these did not cause rising numbers of plagiarism among students.’ Another instructor said, ‘The world is changing, and so should we. We cannot continue teaching the way we used to.’

Acknowledging the technology’s potential

Instructors agreed that ChatGPT can alleviate some of their workload by automating tasks such as quiz creation, content summarization, and outline generation. Additionally, they noted that ChatGPT offers an interactive learning environment tailored to individual learner needs as well as immediate feedback on both language use and content in learners’ written work. Although learners found AI feedback useful, they recognized that it cannot fully replace feedback from instructors. One instructor expressed optimism about integrating AI into future EFL textbooks, envisioning a shift from traditional supplementary textbook materials to specialized AI that can provide learners with personalized quizzes and explanations for challenging material. She remarked, ‘I think we will notice a revolution in EFL textbooks. Smart EFL chatbots will be soon part of the curriculum. They can trace the progress of every student and also offer exercises designed for their own needs.... AI chatbots will also suit the preferences of a large proportion of the next high-tech EFL generation.’

Based on their experience, the instructors believed ChatGPT could greatly help EFL learners in terms of enhancing their communication skills, proofreading their texts, crafting more engaging and descriptive sentences, identifying errors, and providing language learning advice, among other benefits. They noted that AI can boost learners’ productivity, enhance the quality of their language, diversify their vocabulary, suggest synonyms, brainstorm ideas, and help overcome writer’s block. One instructor said, ‘ChatGPT helped them write engaging and descriptive expressions. Instead of simply stating, “I was excited,” [they could say], “I was absolutely brimming with anticipation.”’ They recommended requiring learners to compare their writing with ChatGPT’s output to identify and learn from the differences. One instructor found it

especially useful to have learners submit their work both before and after using ChatGPT and to occasionally include the entire ChatGPT conversation. Another instructor observed an improvement in her EFL learners' pragmatic competence, noting that she began receiving 'more polite and well-structured e-mails than before ChatGPT.' Other instructors found ChatGPT especially useful for listening and reading. ChatGPT is adept at generating new reading passages and audio that incorporate newly learned vocabulary in a meaningful context, tailored to learners' proficiency levels. One participant said,

My students got direct answers to their questions in a conversational setting. This helped to reduce the time they spend on searching and enabled them to focus on the more important concepts. It also allowed them to explore topics in more depth than I could cover in class. ChatGPT also provided personalized guidance for each student, allowing them to get the most out of their study time.

Strategies to minimize the risk of ChatGPT misuse

Instructors compared plagiarism using ChatGPT to plagiarism using other methods. According to them, unethical AI use is just one aspect of the broader issue of plagiarism in educational settings. The issue with AI is that it is freely accessible and therefore more widely available. One instructor humorously remarked, 'ChatGPT democratizes plagiarism for learners of different income levels.' Thus, the instructors argued that previous strategies for detecting plagiarism can still be applied. Key strategies they suggested included educating learners about the importance of academic integrity and the serious implications of plagiarism, discussing submitted work with learners to ensure they wrote it themselves, asking learners to write a summary of their work after submission, and maintaining open communication with learners to understand their individual needs.

Some instructors suggested requiring multiple drafts of submitted work, with some drafts created in class, to reduce the likelihood of plagiarism. They also recommended including a personal element in assignments, such as a personal experience or specific details that AI cannot generate. Additionally, asking learners to cite references was suggested by the participants to discourage total dependence on AI. An instructor familiar with each learner's level can often discern whether an assignment was written by the learner or AI. Moreover, an instructor pointed out that making AI use transparent reduces the likelihood of cheating because learners are aware of their instructors' knowledge of their ChatGPT use. She said, 'When students are aware that their teacher is also aware of their use of ChatGPT for the course, they tend to refrain from cheating.'

Characteristics that mark AI-generated responses

Instructors who frequently use ChatGPT become familiar with its typical response traits, such as generality and a tendency toward objectivity and impersonality. As the instructors confirmed, AI-generated language is nearly flawless in grammar and syntax and often incorporates sophisticated vocabulary that is less commonly used, which might not align with the language proficiency of learners. For instance, an instructor noted that a level-one learner submitted a written assignment on ‘picnics’ that unexpectedly contained advanced vocabulary and eloquent language, as in the following from the submitted paragraph: ‘The vibrant greenery and serene atmosphere provided a backdrop for camaraderie and casual conversations unfolding among the friends.’ It was later discovered that the learner had ChatGPT write the assignment.

Based on the instructors’ experience, AI-generated responses often contain detailed content elements that might be difficult for learners to gather within the time constraints of an assignment. These responses typically lack proper references or might include fabricated ones. Some sentences are notably lengthy and complex. When tasked with expanding a short paragraph, AI tends to insert overly general or introductory statements, such as definitions, amid the topic details. A common characteristic of AI-produced text is a lack of coherence between sentences and ideas. Moreover, AI often produces long passages that fail to provide new information. The responses might also contain inaccuracies and misinformation. Therefore, the instructors highlighted the need to encourage learners to verify the accuracy of information in AI-generated content. As one noted, ‘This is because AI tools like ChatGPT are still far from perfect, and responses might contain errors.’ One instructor noted that ChatGPT seems to exhibit a ‘white, Western’ perspective, which could lead to cultural bias in the information presented. In summary, all instructors emphasized the importance of teachers becoming acquainted with AI-generated text as a strategy to curb the unethical use of such tools.

The need for an updated definition of plagiarism and AI ethics-related policies

All instructors agreed that controlling or limiting the use of ChatGPT and similar AI tools is not practically feasible. Thus, there is a need to revise outdated definitions of plagiarism. According to the instructors, using ChatGPT to refine written work should not be considered plagiarism. However, they stressed that learners should acknowledge AI contributions in their citations and specify the sections where AI was used. One

instructor, ‘Directly having AI complete an assignment is cheating. It is imperative to establish, publicize, and discuss with learners clear guidelines for the ethical use of AI tools in education. The institution must unify its stance on what is permissible regarding learners’ use of AI to prevent confusion from inconsistent rules set by different instructors.’ Additionally, participants argued that the educational system should prioritize learning over grading. Placing higher value on grades than skills ‘can drive learners to seek any help, including unethical means, to boost their GPA.’ One instructor suggested that the root of all plagiarism is the learner’s pressure to achieve a high or satisfactory grade to pass a course. If EFL assessments allocated a significant portion of the grade to the learning process rather than the final product, learners would be less inclined to plagiarize.

Importance of age and maturity

Learners’ age and maturity level are key factors that can influence the likelihood of integrating AI tools in an EFL context. Young learners might not recognize the potential risks associated with misusing these tools. Consequently, it has been proposed that there should be greater restrictions on AI use in educational settings for those below a certain maturity threshold. Some instructors believe that tools such as ChatGPT should only be permitted when a learner is sufficiently mature to avoid misusing them. This is analogous to allowing the use of calculators only after learners have mastered fundamental arithmetic skills.

Discussion

Quantitative results

The patterns in the quantitative results for both instructors and learners were largely parallel and did not differ substantially. Learners’ perceptions were consistent with the findings of An et al. (2023) and Mahapatra (2024). The quantitative analysis of the survey data indicated that learners recognized ChatGPT’s benefits and expressed a desire for earlier access to it. Instructors also perceived ChatGPT as highly effective for supporting learning across all EFL courses, echoing Liu and Ma (2023). The positive attitude toward ChatGPT use in EFL in this study is consistent with Gao et al. (2024), Jeon and Lee (2023), and Mahapatra (2024). However, a significant number of learners preferred to conceal their ChatGPT use from their instructors, opting to submit ChatGPT-generated assignments rather than submit nothing at all. Some would let ChatGPT complete their work, if possible. Despite learners’ attempts at honesty, these findings raise concerns about the unsupervised

or unethical use of AI tools, echoing concerns raised by Ibrahim et al. (2023), Tlili et al. (2023), Gao et al. (2024), Kohnke et al. (2023), and Jeon and Lee (2023).

ChatGPT and EFL writing

Instructors and learners both found ChatGPT especially beneficial for writing classes, in which AI can enhance learner productivity, elevate language quality, diversify vocabulary, provide synonyms, and help overcome writer's block. This finding aligns with Jarrah et al. (2023) and Mahapatra (2024). In this study, learners emphasized that writing is the domain where ChatGPT proves most useful, offering tailored responses to each learner's needs, as previously noted by Farrokhniaa et al. (2023) and Mahapatra (2024). Additionally, learners and instructors believed that written assignments in content courses, such as English literature and linguistics, can be improved significantly with AI assistance. Mahapatra (2024) and Gao et al. (2024) reported similar findings. Additionally, participant instructors saw potential for ChatGPT in translation courses, though learners were slightly less convinced.

ChatGPT and EFL communication

In terms of enhancing EFL communication, instructors and learners were both skeptical about the usefulness of ChatGPT compared with the case of writing. This was unexpected, given that ChatGPT is an interactive chatbot designed to serve as a communication partner. Previous studies highlighted ChatGPT's ability to facilitate asynchronous communication as one of its main benefits (Cotton et al., 2023; Jeon & Lee, 2023; Ji et al., 2022; Kohnke et al., 2023; Liu & Ma, 2023). However, this study aligns more with Ji et al. (2022), who noted learners' dwindling interest in AI conversation after initial exposure, along with frequent misinterpretations, leading to communication breakdowns. Meanwhile, instructors and learners both reacted positively to ChatGPT's immediate feedback on learners' work, a feature that teachers likened to a private tutor, and which learners appreciated. Previous studies have recognized the value of personalized, real-time responses (An et al., 2023; Farrokhniaa et al., 2023; Jeon & Lee, 2023; Kohnke et al., 2023; Liu & Ma, 2023; Mahapatra, 2024).

Features of ChatGPT that might lead to misuse

Reducing the likelihood of AI plagiarism requires focusing on ChatGPT features that might encourage unethical use. The main factors here include the uniqueness of responses and adherence to word limits and language levels. Instructors and learners agreed that ChatGPT's ability to precisely meet an assignment's word-count requirements and to generate

multiple unique responses from the same prompt are important factors that might tempt learners to misuse it. Some also regarded ChatGPT's ability to produce responses at the learner's level as a potential incentive to cheat. Most, however, did not view the inability of plagiarism detection software to identify ChatGPT responses as a major enabler of misuse. This might have stemmed from participants' ignorance about the inaccuracy of AI-detection tools, as reported in previous research (e.g. Gorichanaz, 2023; Ibrahim et al., 2023; Mijwil et al., 2023) or their belief that technology will soon provide reliable AI language detectors.

Strategies for reducing the risk of AI-induced plagiarism

Instructors were divided on the idea of limiting ChatGPT's use to only classwork, partly because such a restriction might be unfeasible. They also expressed skepticism about confining learner assessments solely to classwork. This is consistent with Gorichanaz (2023), who called for a reassessment of evaluation methods. The instructors' views lend credence to Stokel-Walker (2023) and Yeadon et al. (2022), who predict that essays will become obsolete in educational assessment, as well as Farrokhniaa et al. (2023), who asserted that summative assessments are no longer reliable in the AI era. This also supports Gorichanaz's (2023) recommendation to prioritize the assessment of the learning process over the final product, given the availability of ChatGPT.

In line with Cotton et al. (2023), most instructors agreed about the effectiveness of comparing learners' actual classwork performance with their submitted homework to determine whether they overly depend on ChatGPT. Instructors also agreed that discussing answers with learners can help verify their authenticity. They advocated for a shift in task design, such as comparing learner essays with those generated by ChatGPT, aligning with Farrokhniaa et al. (2023). Moreover, nearly all instructors emphasized the importance of enhancing discussions of ethical responsibilities and raising awareness about the serious repercussions of plagiarism to promote positive ChatGPT use, a sentiment also supported by previous research (Cotton et al., 2023; Kasneci et al., 2023; Kohnke et al., 2023).

Qualitative results

The qualitative analysis of the open-ended questions and instructors' interviews supported and helped explain the quantitative results. They revealed that instructors focused more on AI's potential to support EFL learning than on the risk of plagiarism. This aligns with Tlili et al. (2023), who found that positive social media posts about AI occurred twice as frequently as negative ones. Instructors agreed with Cotton et al. (2023), Gao et al. (2024), and Kohnke et al. (2023) that ChatGPT can

boost learner engagement. Consistent with An et al. (2023), instructors asserted that AI effectiveness in EFL classes could vary depending on learners' age and EFL proficiency levels.

Instructors recognized that ChatGPT-related plagiarism is part of the broader issue of academic integrity. Effective communication and discussion about academic work were seen as key to reducing negative AI use, with transparency being crucial for positive ChatGPT use. Instructors highlighted the need to remind learners about the proper citation and acknowledgment of ChatGPT in their work, aligning with Jarrah et al. (2023), who called for the precise documentation of AI assistance. McAdoo (2023) suggested that APA guidelines for citing AI should be followed, with learners specifying AI-assisted sections or listing ChatGPT as a coauthor, similar to Jarrah et al. (2023), O'Connor and ChatGPT (2023), and Stokel-Walker (2023). Additionally, instructors emphasized the importance of verifying the accuracy of ChatGPT's information, echoing concerns raised by Gao et al. (2024), Kohnke et al. (2023), Tlili et al. (2023), and Farrokhniaa et al. (2023).

Some indicators of AI-generated content include an impersonal tone and a lack of valid sources and citations. To deter potential ChatGPT misuse, instructors suggested incorporating personal elements into assignments that AI cannot replicate. This aligns with Cotton et al. (2023), who proposed that clear, detailed assignment instructions can help minimize unethical AI use. Moreover, requiring learners to cite references can help, as noted by the participants. Instructors also saw a need for an updated definition of plagiarism to address the challenges posed by AI, echoing Gorichanaz (2023). Learners should be explicitly informed about what constitutes unethical ChatGPT use, and educational institutions should establish clear policies regarding AI's role in academic work, echoing Cotton et al. (2023), Gorichanaz (2023), and Kohnke et al. (2023). Different from Kasneci et al. (2023), instructors believed AI should not be allowed for early-stage language learners or younger learners, who need to focus on developing their skills without AI assistance. This is consistent, however, with Ji et al. (2022), who noted that early-stage language learners face more communication challenges with AI and gain more confidence from interactions with human peers.

Conclusion

This study compared instructors' and learners' views regarding ChatGPT use in EFL classes after using ChatGPT for a whole academic trimester. Based on both quantitative and qualitative results, this study also considered the relationship between ChatGPT and academic integrity. Both groups acknowledged AI's effectiveness for improving EFL learning in

general and EFL writing in particular. However, a conflict was highlighted between AI's advantages for EFL education and its potential effects on academic honesty. ChatGPT's unique responses and its adherence to word limits and language levels could encourage unethical use. Thus, explicit rules should be established for the appropriate use of ChatGPT and similar technologies in EFL instruction. There should also be open, proper acknowledgment of AI assistance in written work. The educational system faces major changes as AI continues to advance. Instructors should engage with this transformation by adjusting their teaching and assessment methods to align with advancements in AI. EFL textbook developers should consider incorporating an AI component to support learners and cater to their individual needs.

Limitations

This study's findings are specific to the women's Saudi university where it was conducted. The participants were homogeneous—all female EFL learners and instructors with Arabic as their first language. We must be cautious, then, about generalizing the findings. Additionally, this study relied on subjective, self-reported responses from instructors and learners; outcomes could be different if more objective data collection methods are used. Further, this research was conducted following the release of ChatGPT 3.5. Future updates to ChatGPT and similar tools might affect the study's relevance and the applicability of its findings. Further experimental research will be needed to validate this study's findings. Assessments of AI's effectiveness should include diverse EFL learner populations, considering variables such as proficiency level and age. Furthermore, while this study explored the perspectives of EFL learners and instructors regarding the relationship between ChatGPT and academic integrity, these perspectives need to be validated through objective, quantitative experimental research.

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The author reports no potential conflicts of interest.

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Data availability statement

Access to anonymized datasets related to this project is available upon request.

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